whom he did not like). On prime-time television, we journalists appreciated Smriti's willingness for a fiery joust—she always came to shows well prepared and spoiling for a good fight. As a Rajya Sabha MP taking on Rahul, she had nothing to lose. 'I am going to Amethi to win—it's not a token fight,' she told me.

Also fighting from Amethi was the AAP, which put up Kumar Vishwas, another TV-savvy neta. Unlike Smriti who saw Amethi as another step up the political ladder, Vishwas was looking for his fifteen minutes of fame. A Hindi poet, he was a great favourite on Hindi news TV because of his quick wit and sharp one-liners. I told him once in an interview that he was being seen as a 'joker in the pack' in Amethi. Pat came the reply: *'Circus mein sabkee nigahein joker par hee toh hotee hai!'* (In a circus, all eyes are on the joker.)

Rahul and Priyanka versus Smriti versus Vishwas—Amethi had suddenly become a made-for-TV high-profile contest. Priyanka knew she was in a contest this time, which is why she decided to raise the pitch. The moment she stepped out to address rallies, she became the Pied Piper of Amethi. Cameras would follow her everywhere. It became a media circus. The message to the newsroom was that one reporter must track Priyanka all the time—you never know what she would say where. Chasing Priyanka wasn't easy for the swarm of journalists. They had to fight not just the heat but the SPG as well.

My former colleague Shreya Dhoundial was assigned the task of trailing Priyanka. She describes to me a typical day. 9 a.m.: stand outside the Munshiganj guest house; 10.30 a.m.: thrust your mike at the car window as Priyanka's car leaves the gate but with no luck; 10.35: start chasing the car with around fifty other crew and OB vans, with the SPG fleet as an immovable barrier in the middle; 11 a.m.: Priyanka stops to meet people, so you stop, try and shoulder your way through the circle of towering AK-47-wielding commandos, get your mike as far forward as you can towards her, she just smiles and drives away. 'Finally, we struck a deal. If Priyanka spoke to us once every morning for even thirty seconds, then we would leave her alone for the rest of the day,' Shreya told me later.